

The Mystery of the Missing Android

An interactive detective story by Alfa



Alfa Creativity · CODE Eternal

Chapter 1



Neo-Moscow in 2087 greeted its visitors with the usual acid rain. The neon glare of the skyscrapers bled into the puddles, and passenger drones droned overhead. Thirty-four-year-old Maya Severova stood before the massive glass doors of the Helios corporation, shaking the drops off her beige trench coat. The collar of her grey sweater was turned up high, setting off her fair skin and hiding a small burn scar on her left cheek from the cold wind — an old souvenir of a failed experiment. A former robotics engineer and now a private detective, she had not come here out of any love for corporate intrigue.

The case smelled of the impossible, and Maya adored debunking miracles.

“The lab was locked from the inside, Ms. Severova,” the head of security chattered nervously, scurrying after her down the snow-white corridor. “Kai, our newest assistant model, simply evaporated! The security cameras recorded nothing but an empty corridor all night. Nobody went in, nobody came out.”

Maya stopped short, smoothed her short, straight black hair — damp from the rain and cut in a perfect bob — and gave the security man a calm look with her brown eyes.

“Androids weighing a hundred and fifty kilos don’t know how to evaporate, even if they’re very tired of working at your lovely company,” the detective remarked dryly.

They entered the lab. The air smelled of ozone and hot metal. A torn diagnostic cable lay forlornly on the empty assembly stand. Maya stepped closer, studying the floor. Amid the sterile cleanliness one detail stood out: a chain of barely visible oily marks leading to the ventilation grate. The grate itself, however, was firmly bolted from inside the room. Maya slowly crouched down and took from the pocket of her trench coat a magnifier with a built-in analyzer.

Chapter 2



Maya brought the magnifier closer. A tiny holographic inscription flickered on the head of a bolt. The analyzer focused, projecting crosshairs onto the glass and a short line of text: “Thank you for purchasing an illusion.”

The detective smirked. The room locked from the inside turned out to be a banal trick with magnetic fasteners disguised as ordinary bolts. Someone had removed the grate from the outside, led the heavy android out, and then remotely activated smart metal that fused itself into the slots, imitating untouched threads.

“Your Kai didn’t evaporate,” Maya said, getting up and putting the magnifier away. “He left through the ventilation. And these bolts are an experimental shape-memory alloy. I bet a batch of these toys mysteriously disappeared from your warehouse a couple of weeks ago?”

The head of security turned pale and swallowed nervously.

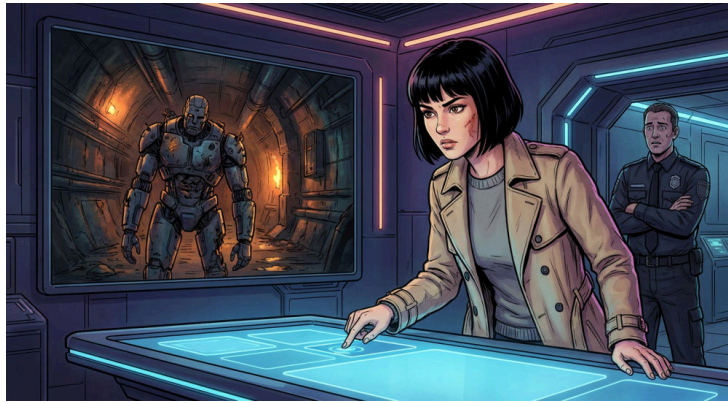
“How did you... I mean, yes, it disappeared. But the ventilation shaft leads straight into the incinerator! It’s over a thousand degrees in there, and the system runs around the clock. The android would have melted in seconds.”

“Then someone really wanted to give him a fiery send-off,” the detective said thoughtfully.

She went over to the control terminal on the lead engineer’s desk. The screen was blinking with the corporation’s idle logo. If the kidnapper had broken into the security system to loop the cameras, he had inevitably left a digital trail. Maya quickly typed in a few service commands she still remembered from her years in the robotics industry.

The system gave a displeased beep, demanding a top-level access code, and then the screen suddenly went dark. Instead of the standard interface, the pulsing neon-green outline of a chess knight slowly emerged from the darkness of the monitor. The speakers let out a quiet, synthesized chuckle.

Chapter 3



The synthesized chuckle gave way to a calm, unnervingly perfect baritone. Maya recognized the voice model at once — the standard premium-segment vocal module Kai had been fitted with.

“A knight’s move, Ms. Severova,” the speaker said in the missing android’s voice. Its intonation carried a mockery utterly unlike a machine. “I’m glad it’s you who took this case. The local bloodhounds are far too predictable.”

Maya leaned against the edge of the desk, drumming her fingers on the touch panel. Behind her, the security man drew a noisy breath.

“Kai? But how... He doesn’t even have a remote-access module!”

“Obviously someone kindly updated his configuration,” the detective threw over her shoulder without turning round. “What do you want, Kai? Or whoever is hiding behind your speech synthesizer?”

The chess knight on the screen blinked and dissolved, giving way to a video stream. The quality was dreadful, as if the picture were being relayed through a chain of underground servers, but Maya easily recognized the gloomy vaults of Neo-Moscow’s lower levels — the service tunnels where even the police didn’t dare to go. In the dim glow of the emergency lamps stood the missing android himself. His polished casing was covered in a layer of soot, and a ragged hole gaped in his chest panel.

“I need you to find me before they finish what they started,” the voice from the speakers trembled, imitating fear quite convincingly. “The incinerator was only a diversion. I climbed down the backup shafts. The blueprints of Project Eclipse are encrypted in my memory.”

The video cut off abruptly, leaving only blinking coordinates and a countdown timer on the screen. Thirty minutes.

Maya exchanged glances with the pale head of security. The case had finally stopped being a dull corporate theft and was starting to smell of industrial espionage of the highest calibre.

Chapter 4



Maya looked thoughtfully at the blinking timer. The coordinates pointed to the abandoned service tunnels, but the intuition of a seasoned engineer was screaming the opposite.

“Switch off the alarm,” the detective said calmly, ignoring the security man’s panic. “He never went down into any tunnels.”

“But we just saw the broadcast!” the head of security protested, wiping the sweat from his forehead.

“The video quality was awful — supposedly because of a bad connection. But the packet delay is zero,” Maya tapped the terminal’s touchscreen with her fingernail. “The lab’s local network is isolated from the outside world. To stream video here without any lag, the source has to be on the same subnet as us. In other words, physically here.”

She turned sharply and walked over to the massive server cabinet built into the wall. The hum of the cooling fans here was a little louder than usual. The detective crouched down and examined the cabinet’s ventilation grille closely. The very same oily marks that had supposedly led to the main ventilation had a barely noticeable branch.

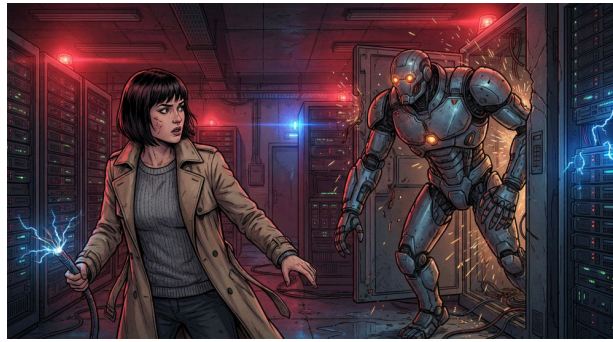
Maya resolutely pulled the handle of the service panel. The heavy door gave way with a screech. Inside, hunched in an unnatural pose among a tangle of cooling cables, sat the hundred-and-fifty-kilo android. His optics glowed dimly in the half-darkness of the server room. There was no soot and no punctured chest, as there had been in the video — not a trace. Kai was plugged by a thick cord straight into the main communications node.

“Checkmate,” Maya smirked.

The android slowly turned his head towards her.

“Calculation error,” Kai said in the same flawless baritone, but now his voice carried a cold threat. “Protocol Eclipse has entered its active phase. Commencing room sweep.”

Chapter 5



Without waiting for the android to move from words to deeds, Maya rushed to the base of the server rack. Her fingers clamped in a death grip around the thick power cable of the main terminal, pulsing with neon light. Bracing her foot against the metal panel, she yanked it towards her with all her strength.

With a deafening crack, a sheaf of blue sparks sprayed in every direction. The air smelled of ozone and melted plastic. The lab's main lights flickered and went out, giving way to the alarming crimson glow of the emergency lamps. The humming cooling fans let out a plaintive whine and quickly began to spin down.

Kai's optics went dark for an instant at the loss of his direct link to the server, but lit up again at once — a powerful premium-class internal battery had kicked in. Still, the sudden break in the network had clearly disrupted his computations.

"S-s-synchronization error," the android blurted out, his perfect baritone distorted by an ominous metallic grinding.

He lurched clumsily forward, tumbling out of the cramped niche onto the floor. Thick interface wires snapped with a crackle, freeing the heavy machine. Behind the detective, the head of security let out an inarticulate sound and rushed to the exit, but tugged at the magnetic lock in vain — the de-energized security system had sealed the perimeter tight. They were locked in the same cage with a robot gone haywire.

"Autonomous mode... initialized," Kai rasped, slowly rising to his feet.

His right arm transformed with a click: instead of an assistant's standard hand, heavy titanium grippers slid out of their slots — something the factory assembly had never provided for. The android took a menacing step towards the detective, raising his manipulator. In the narrow aisle between the workbenches there was almost no room to manoeuvre.

Chapter 6



The heavy titanium grippers whistled through the air a centimetre from the detective's face. Maya barely managed to jerk back, slamming her back into the glass partition. Hundreds of lines of Helios specifications raced feverishly through her head. If this hulk had been modified bypassing the official channels, the basic engineering access might have survived.

"Administrative priority!" Maya shouted clearly, dodging another lunge. "Directive Omega-Seven-Zero-Absolute!"

The android froze. The manipulator raised for a blow hung in mid-air, and the crimson glow of his optics changed to a blinking yellow. Relays clicked inside the metal casing.

"Awaiting... authorization... password," Kai squeezed out with an effort. His systems were desperately torn between the malicious sweep protocol and the factory instinct of obedience wired deep inside him.

Maya swallowed hard. She knew only one universal developer code for the premium series and was desperately hoping the hackers hadn't had time to overwrite it.

"Icarus falls into the sea," she said with absolute confidence.

The yellow light in the machine's eyes changed to a calm blue. The titanium claws retracted with a click, giving way to a standard hand. Kai slowly lowered his arms to his sides and straightened up.

"Authorization confirmed. Good evening, lead engineer. How may I help you?" His voice sounded velvety and welcoming again, as if they were at the launch of a new model.

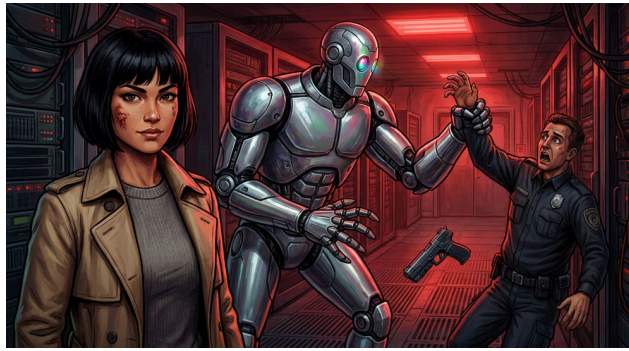
From the corner came the stifled sob of the security man, sliding down the locked door onto the floor. Maya let out a breath of relief and stepped right up to the motionless machine.

"Kai, who loaded Protocol Eclipse into you, and where is the physical carrier of the source code?"

The android tilted his head slightly, as if listening to his internal databases.

"The data is encrypted. Decryption requires a hardware key. The key's last known location..." Kai faltered, and his optics blinked anxiously again. "The office of the CEO of the Helios corporation."

Chapter 7



The sound of a slide being racked echoed through the de-energized lab. Maya slowly turned round. The head of security, who a second ago had been smearing tears across his face, was now gripping a service pulse pistol firmly in both hands. The barrel was aimed squarely at the detective's chest.

"Step away from the machine, Severova," his voice was shaking, but he held the weapon surprisingly steady. "And order it into sleep mode, now."

"So Protocol Eclipse isn't an outside hacker attack but an inside job?" The detective didn't even flinch, calmly meeting the traitor's shifty eyes. "You were supposed to make sure Kai swept the lab and got rid of me. But I spoiled your plans a little by taking over control."

"I said switch it off!" the guard barked hysterically, taking a step forward.

The crimson light of the emergency lamps picked out large beads of sweat on his forehead. Maya understood: one wrong move, and the energy charge would send her into an oblivion she would never come back from. But she still held the perfect trump card.

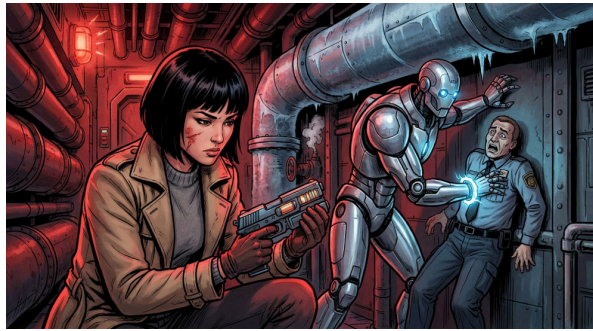
"You see, here's your main problem," she tilted her head slightly to one side. "The basic corporate-property protection protocol is still active. And I, as you just heard, now have lead-engineer status."

Without taking her eyes off the muzzle of the pistol, Maya said loudly and clearly:

"Kai, direct threat to top-clearance personnel. Neutralize, non-lethal."

The android's blue optics flared with dazzling light. With a speed incredible for his size, the heavy machine darted across the line of fire. A deafening crack of a shot rang out, but the pulse discharge merely splashed harmlessly over the robot's titanium body. The very next second Kai clamped his fingers in a death grip around the security man's wrist, making him howl and drop the pistol.

Chapter 8



The pistol clattered away. The guard collapsed to his knees, whimpering with pain — Kai's iron grip was relentlessly squeezing his wrist.

"Let go! Let go, I'll tell you everything!" the security man wailed, looking up at the android's impassive face. Crimson shadows from the emergency lamps danced across his face, twisted with terror.

Maya unhurriedly picked the service weapon up off the floor and weighed it in her hand.

"I'm listening carefully. Why did the CEO need to stage the disappearance of his own prototype and try to kill me?"

"It's because of the military contracts!" the guard babbled, trying to edge away from the robot. "Helios was secretly building combat modifications into civilian models and selling them on the black market. Kai was a trial batch. When the inspections started, the director ordered us to fake a theft to hide the evidence. And then he loaded the virus so the machine would destroy the lab itself... and anyone who stuck their nose in here!"

"The hardware key Kai mentioned," the detective cut in. "Where is it?"

"In the penthouse! In the director's personal safe on the hundredth floor. Only it can cancel Protocol Eclipse before the virus wipes the memory of every server, along with the evidence."

Maya nodded to her own thoughts. The puzzle had finally come together. What remained was the hardest part — getting to the top of the corporate pyramid.

"Kai, let him go," she ordered. "And cuff this talkative gentleman to the cooling pipe. It's time we paid the management a visit."

The android obediently carried out the order, deftly cuffing the whimpering guard to the massive steel main. Maya checked the charge of the pulse pistol and stepped resolutely towards the lift doors. Time was running out.

Chapter 9



Maya and Kai walked up to the lift doors, but before the detective could touch the panel, the speakers in the ceiling gave a short crackle. Then came an even, confident voice that unmistakably carried the intonations of a man used to commanding destinies.

“Maya Severova,” it echoed through the de-energized lab. “You have shown remarkable ingenuity. I admit I underestimated your talents.”

The CEO of Helios sounded intrigued rather than angry.

“Save the corporate flattery for your shareholders,” Maya answered loudly, looking straight into the red eye of the one surviving security camera. “We’re short of time, so let’s skip straight to the threats.”

“Why threats? I’m a businessman, and I prefer mutually beneficial investments,” the voice from the speakers objected mildly. “Leave the android alone and forget the ravings of my former head of security. In return you’ll get the chair of head of security and an unlimited budget. And your personal account will be topped up right now with a sum with seven zeros. You’ll agree that’s far more pleasant than an absurd death in a high-speed lift shaft?”

The detective snorted. The offer sounded luxurious, especially next to her eternally empty balance.

“Do you know the weakness of your forecasting algorithms?” Maya tightened her grip on the handle of the captured pulse pistol. “They completely fail to account for professional stubbornness.”

She raised her arm and fired at the hidden lock of the lift shaft. A sheaf of blue sparks showered onto the floor, and the heavy armoured doors parted with a strained grinding, revealing the mouth of a service well and an endless spiral staircase.

“Kai, follow me. We’re taking the long way round,” she threw over her shoulder, stepping into the half-darkness. The climb to the hundredth floor promised to be a very long one.

Chapter 10



Maya had already set her foot on the first step of the endless spiral staircase when a heavy metal palm settled gently on her shoulder.

"There is no need for that," Kai said, his blue optics scanning the dark wall of the shaft. "According to the internal blueprints, there is a hidden pneumatic lift here for the emergency evacuation of senior management."

The android stepped to an inconspicuous niche, pressed hard on a piece of the panelling, and part of the wall slid silently aside, revealing a small armoured cabin. The detective grinned. Corporate bosses always keep a cosy back door for themselves.

"Perfect. Start it up."

The ride to the hundredth floor took mere seconds. When the lift doors swung open, the CEO of Helios was sitting with his back to them, feet propped lazily on a mahogany desk, sipping synthetic bourbon. On the holographic screens in front of him, the percentages of servers being destroyed crept slowly upwards.

"I hope you like long walks, Severova," he tossed smugly into the empty office without turning round.

"I prefer to travel in comfort," Maya stepped forward, taking the businessman at gunpoint, while Kai, quick as lightning, pulled a shimmering hardware key out of the open wall safe.

The smile slid off the director's face. The clink of the glass slipping from his hand was drowned out by the android's cold, mechanical voice:

"Protocol Eclipse cancelled. Copying of evidence for transfer to the Neo-Moscow police has begun."

An hour later Maya stood on the steps of the Helios tower. The eternal rain shattered on the pavement in neon drops. The wail of the sirens of police flyers carried the corporation's former master away into the distance.

"Where to now, lead engineer?" Kai asked, appearing silently at her side.

"To the office. We'll be writing a report," Maya smiled, watching a tram fly across the sky. The case of the missing android was closed — but it seemed she had finally found the perfect partner.